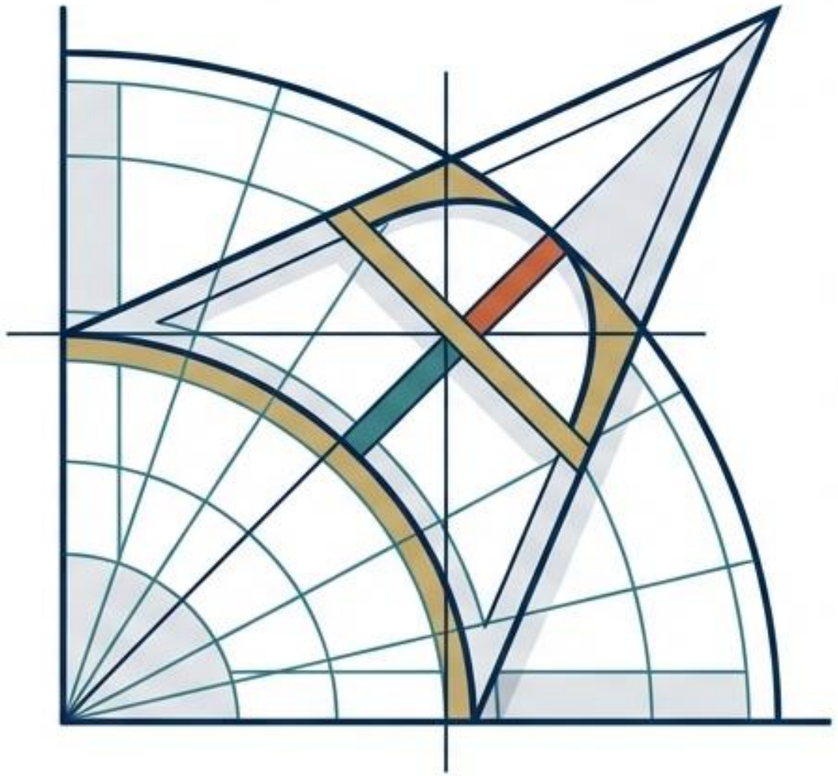
PMP Exam Preparation: The Core Models

A Diagnostic Toolkit for Complexity, Teams, and Change.

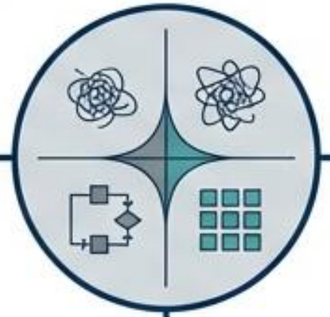


Based on *PMBOK Guide* – Seventh Edition

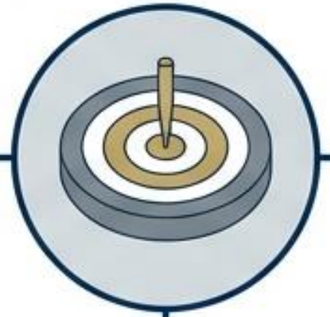
Navigate the exam by identifying the root cause, then selecting the right model.

The Project Manager's Diagnostic Map

Before acting, a PMP must diagnose. Match the scenario to the correct domain to find the solution.



1. Assess Environment
(Cynefin)



2. Identify Who Matters
(Salience)

3. Build the Team
(Tuckman)

4. Lead the People
(Situational II)

5. Coach Performance
(OSCAR)

6. Drive Adoption
(ADKAR)

Assessing Complexity: The Cynefin Framework

Core Concepts

- **Clear:** Cause-and-effect is obvious.
  Action: Best Practice.
- **Complicated:** Known unknowns.
  Action: Good Practice (Analyze).
- **Complex:** Unknown unknowns.
  Action: Emergent Practice.
- **Chaotic:** Crisis/Confusion.
  Action: Stabilize first.

PMP Exam Tip

If the scenario involves a crisis, unknown events, or a need to 'stabilize,' the domain is Chaotic. If it requires experimentation to find a solution, it is Complex.

Prioritizing Stakeholders: The Salience Model

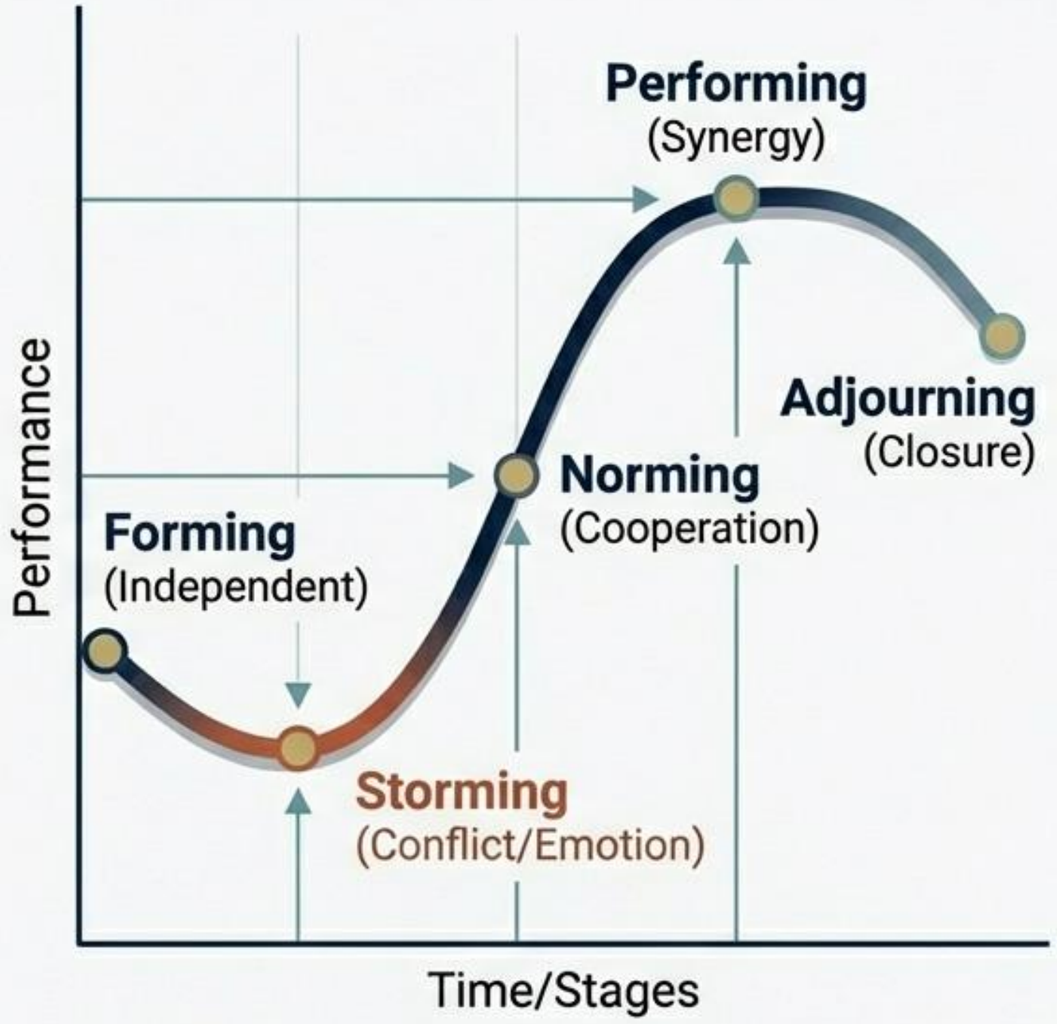
Core Concepts

- **Salience**: Defined as prominent, noticeable, or perceived as important.
- **The Goal**: Classify stakeholders to determine the appropriate level of engagement.

PMP Exam Tip

Stakeholders are not equal. On the exam, look for changes in Urgency (e.g., a safety issue) that shifts a stakeholder from “latent” to “definitive,” requiring the PM’s immediate focus.

Developing the Team: The Tuckman Ladder



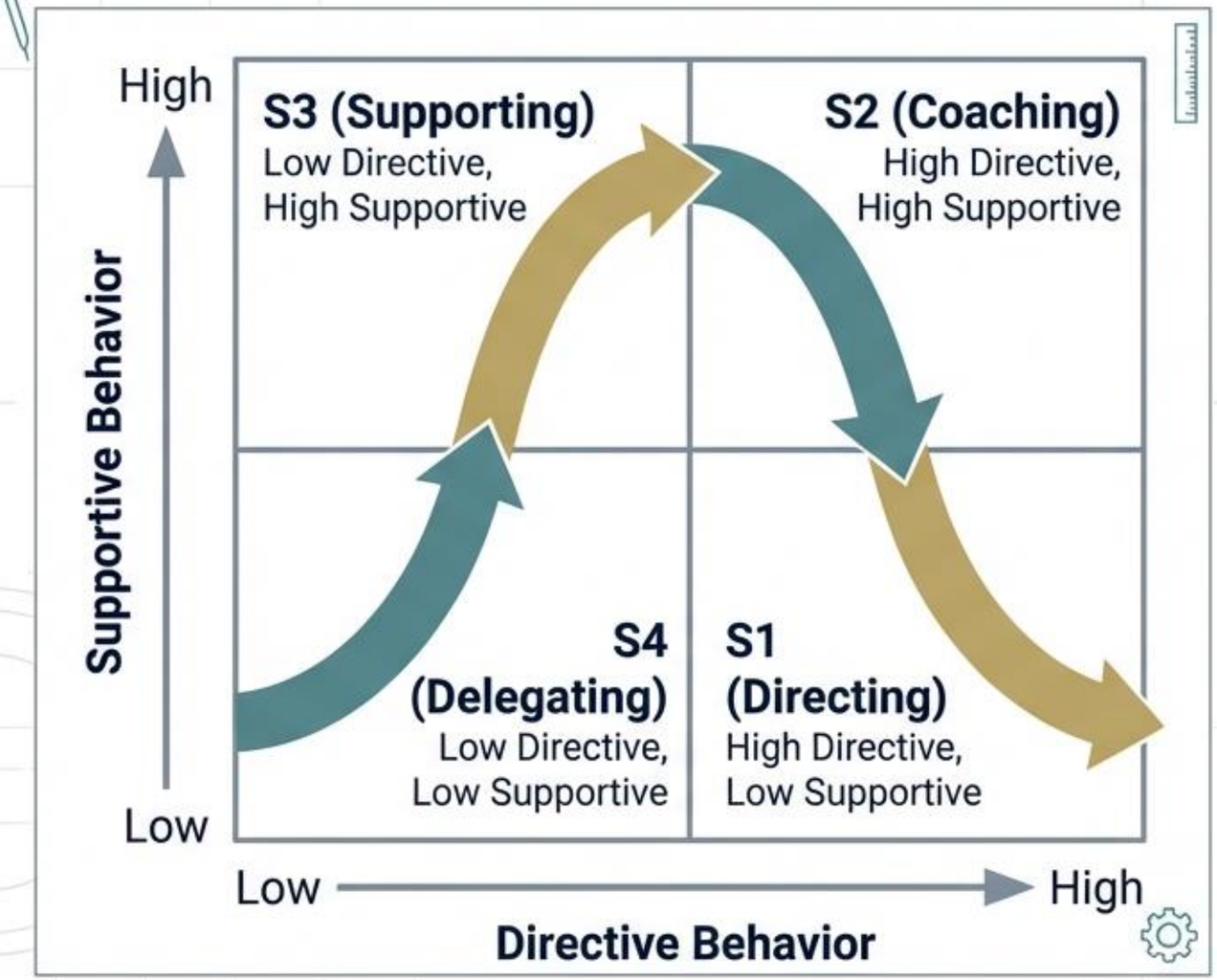
Core Concepts

- **Storming is Normal:** It is the phase where personalities and styles clash; it is necessary for growth.
- **Regression:** Teams can move back and forth between stages.

PMP Exam Tip

If a new member joins or a key member leaves, the team effectively resets. Expect them to revert to Forming or Storming.

Adapting Your Style: Situational Leadership II



Core Concepts

- Low Competence / High Commitment -> Needs Directing.
- High Competence / Low Commitment -> Needs Supporting.
- High Competence / High Commitment -> Needs Delegating.

PMP Exam Tip

Does the team member have the skill? Do they have the will? The answer determines the style. Never micromanage a 'D4' (High/High) expert.

Coaching for Performance: The OSCAR Model

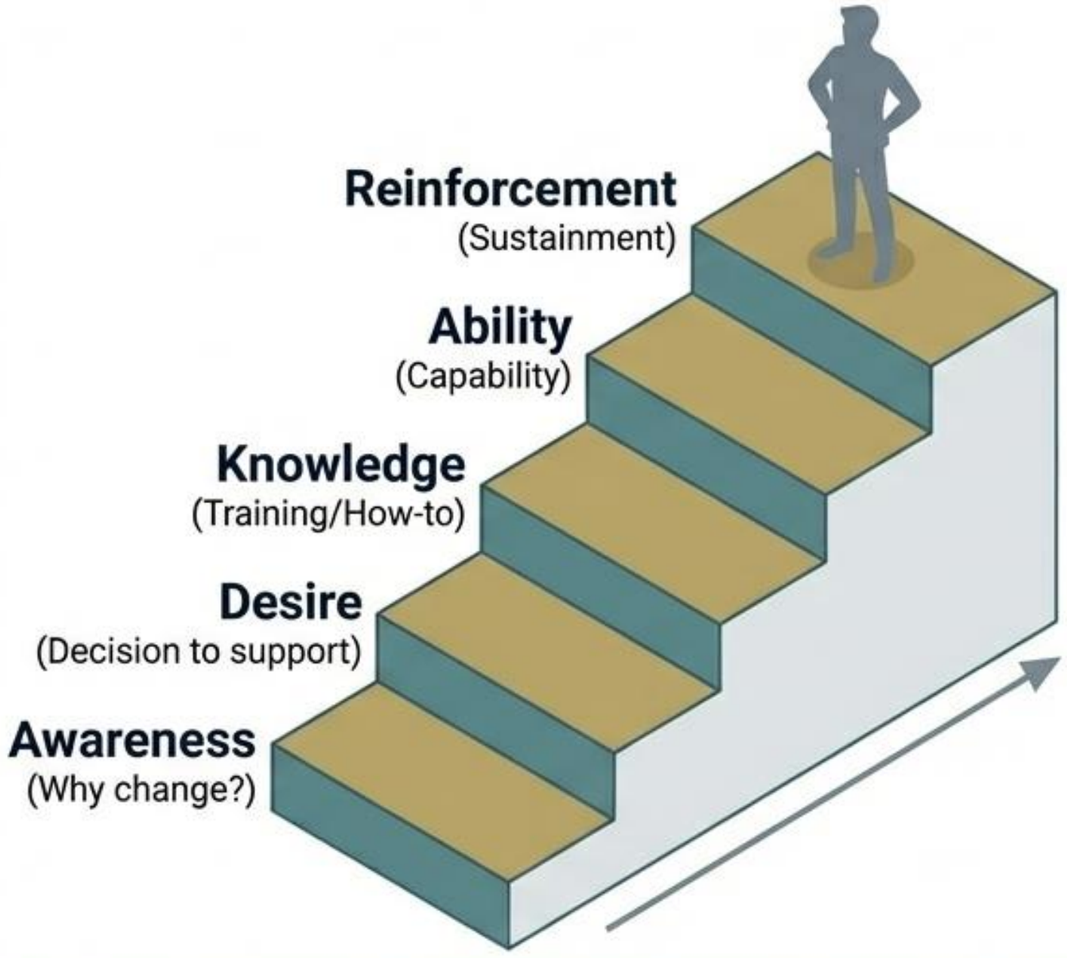
Core Concepts

- A framework for coaching conversations.
- Focuses on solutions (Choices/Actions) rather than dwelling on the problem.

PMP Exam Tip

Use OSCAR when a question describes a one-on-one mentoring scenario regarding a specific performance gap or career development goal.

Navigating Transition: The ADKAR Model



Core Concepts

- Change happens at the individual level first.
- Training (Knowledge) is useless if the user lacks the Desire to change.

PMP Exam Tip

If users are trained but refuse to adopt a new tool, the problem isn't "Knowledge"—it is a lack of Awareness or Desire.

The Diagnostic Matrix (Cheat Sheet)

Trigger Keywords	The Model	The Focus
Chaos, Crisis, Novelty	Cynefin	Decision Context
Conflict, New Hire, Fighting	Tuckman	Team Stages
Power, Urgent, Important	Salience	Stakeholder Priority
Competence, Motivation, Style	Situational II	Leadership Style
Mentoring, Plan, Goals	OSCAR	Individual Coaching
Adoption, Resistance, Training	ADKAR	Change Management

Exam Scenario 1: The Storming Team

The Scenario

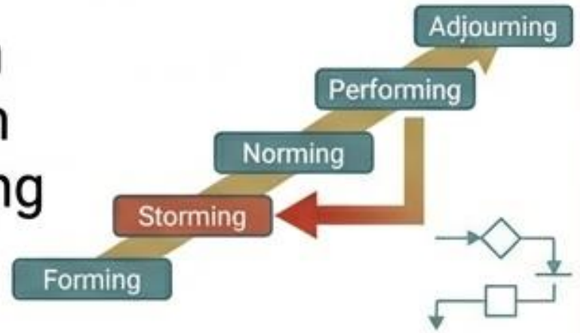
A project team has been working together for two months. A new technical lead is introduced to replace a member who resigned.

Immediately, arguments arise regarding the technical approach, and productivity drops. The sponsor is concerned.

Diagnosis & Result

Model: Tuckman Ladder

Analysis: The team has regressed from Norming/Performing back to Storming.



Correct Response: The PM should not punish the team. Instead, facilitate the conflict and help the team redefine roles. Conflict is expected (and necessary) when membership changes.

Exam Scenario 2: The Chaotic Outage

The Scenario

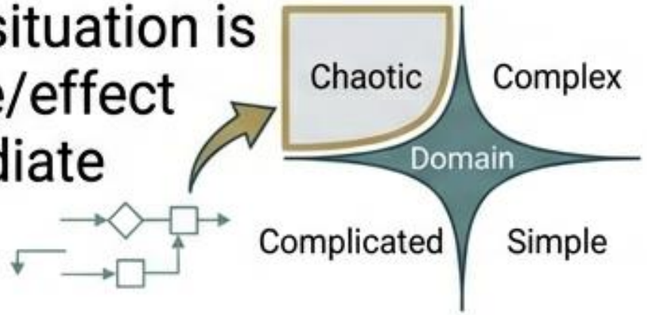
A massive security breach has occurred, compromising client data. There is no existing protocol for this specific type of attack.

The team is paralyzed by the confusion and is asking for a plan.

Diagnosis & Result

Model: Cynefin Framework

Analysis: The situation is Chaotic (cause/effect unclear, immediate threat).



Correct Response: Do not spend time on deep analysis. **Act** first to stabilize the bleeding (contain the breach), then **Sense** the situation, then **Respond**.

Exam Scenario 3: The Reluctant Expert

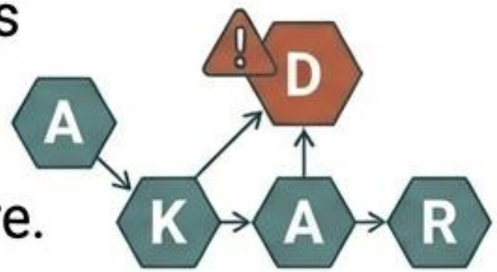
The Scenario

A senior engineer attends all mandatory training for the new time-tracking software. However, two weeks after launch, they continue to use spreadsheets and refuse to log into the new system.

Diagnosis & Result

Model: ADKAR

Analysis: The user has Knowledge (attended training) and likely Ability, but lacks Desire.



Correct Response: Sending them to more training is incorrect. The PM must address the lack of Desire by communicating the benefits and 'why' (Awareness) to build buy-in.

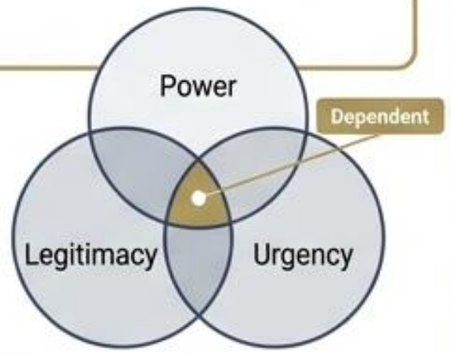
Exam Scenario 4: The Urgent Protest

The Scenario

A local community group is protesting the construction site entrance. They have no contractual authority (Power) to stop work, but their claims are valid (Legitimacy) and they are demanding immediate meetings (Urgency).

Diagnosis & Result

Model: Salience Model



Analysis: This is a 'Dependent Stakeholder' (Urgency + Legitimacy, but low Power).

Correct Response: The PM must monitor this group closely and engage. The risk is that they will partner with a powerful stakeholder (e.g., the media or a politician), gaining Power and becoming 'Definitive'.

Exam Scenario 5: The Variable Team Member

The Scenario

Your team lead is an expert coder (High Competence) who works independently.

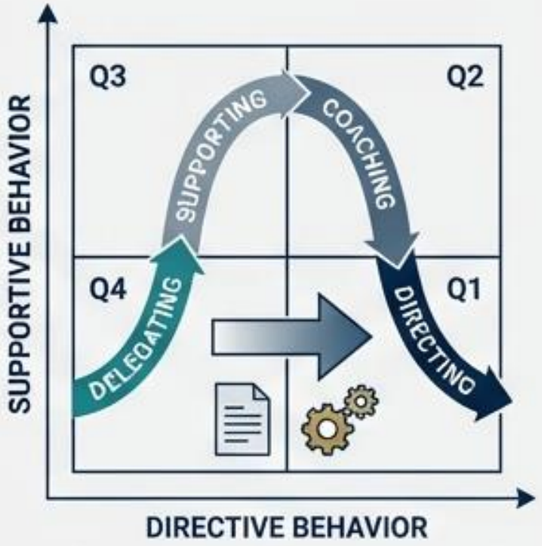
You assign them the task of writing the end-user documentation. They seem anxious, ask repeated questions, and delay starting the work.

Diagnosis & Result

Model: Situational Leadership II

Analysis: While the member is D4 (Delegating) for coding, they are D1 or D2 (Low Competence/Variable Commitment) for documentation.

Correct Response: Switch leadership styles. Stop Delegating; provide Direction or Coaching specific to the documentation task until their competence increases.



The Servant Leader's Mindset

Tailor the Approach	Don't Force It	Focus on Value
As per PMBOK 7th Ed, tailoring is the deliberate adaptation of approach.	Use the model that fits the problem. Don't force a chaotic problem into a linear plan.	The ultimate goal is to enable the team to deliver value to the organization.

"Effective leadership is shown when it best fits a given situation." — PMBOK Guide, 7th Edition